

AFRICAN RAINBOW CRAB

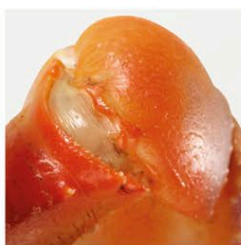
Ocypode (Cardisoma) armatum

African rainbow crabs dig deep individual burrows above the shoreline on sandy beaches, dunes, mangrove swamps, and estuaries. They mate in or near the burrows and females then carry the fertilized eggs under their abdomen for 2–3 weeks before releasing them into shallow water. Millions of floating larvae may be produced by each female per spawn, but only a few survive to make their way back to continue their life on land.



^ UNDERSIDE

The abdomen in males, as shown here, is narrow. In females it is broad and wide for carrying the egg mass.



^ LEG JOINT

Leg joints move in one plane, like a human knee, but each one moves in a different plane, making the crab very agile.

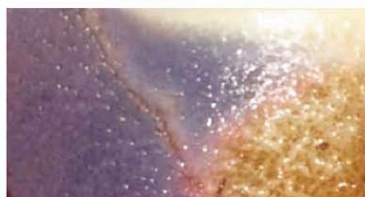
✓ BUCCAL CAVITY

Setae on the outer mouthparts scrub food from particles of sand and pass it inwards to the mandibles



^ EYE

The eyes are on long stalks and can be rotated in their sockets, providing all-round vision for locating food and avoiding predators.



^ SHELL

To increase in size the crab must shed its hard shell, a process called moulting. Water is absorbed into the body until the shell opens up and can be discarded, revealing a new, larger shell beneath.

one of eight walking legs

setae (stiff hairs) are sensitive to touch and help to detect food

sharp leg tip provides excellent dexterity

